

Power Rangers

It is eco-friendly energy that charges the lamps and communication devices in the Dandeli Anshi forest



A FOREST GUARD CHARGES UP

By Nandini Vaish

Last year Sunil Panwar faced a problem. The deputy conservator of forests (wildlife division) at Karnataka's Dandeli Anshi Tiger Reserve was tipped off about the passage of a vehicle, allegedly carrying smuggled cane and wood through Bandeli, near the Goa border. But he could do nothing about it.

Panwar could not inform the anti-poaching camp as the walkie-talkies were out of order—their solar chargers were not working due to continuous rains. Reaching the spot physically wasn't possible either because of bad weather. Panwar's team had often faced such situations. Night patrolling too wasn't easy as the solar lamps could not be recharged in a region which faced nearly three-four months of rain.

The situation underwent a major change after Panwar contacted the Bangalore-based Renewable Energy Applications and Products. The company introduced a bicycle-mounted charger which could power the walkie-talkies as well as the park lights. The rear wheel of the cycle is fitted with a dynamo which charges

the equipment upon pedalling. Around 20 minutes of cycling provide an hour of talk time on the walkie-talkies and light up a street light for about one-two hours. Now the officials have deployed 10 walkie-talkies in the high rainfall areas.

The Dandeli Anshi Tiger Reserve, which is spread over 1,050 sq km, is not easy to cover on foot. As Panwar says: "Even when there wasn't an emergency and if we just had to call for medical supplies or rations, we used to get stuck." Being connected is vital as the reserve houses tigers, melanistic leopards (black panthers) and elephants, among other animals. The last census conducted about five years ago had 33 tigers.

After the eco-friendly bicycle charger, the Forest Department has now replaced CFL lamps with LED bulbs which consume just half the electricity. The bicycle charger experiment, now on for a couple of months, has generated interest among other parks too. Panwar says the Nagarhole National Park near Mysore too is keen on getting a similar system. ■